

ATTITUDES

Six ways to stand inside a hard moment

Raghava KK



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Chapter 1

Opening

Some moments split in two.

Two friends.

Two homes.

Two answers and neither fits.

You try to choose.

Your body freezes instead.

You can feel the pull in both directions.

You can feel something slipping either way.

This book is for those moments.

Not to fix them.

To help you stand inside them.

Chapter 2

What this is

Six attitudes.

Each one is a way of holding a moment
when it feels stuck or divided.

None is the right one.

None is forever.

You try one.

You notice what shifts.

Then you can try another.

This isn't about perfect choices.

It's about learning how to move.

Chapter 3

How to use this book

Open anywhere.

If something feels familiar, stay there.

You don't have to read in order.

You don't have to understand everything.

You just need one small shift.

Chapter 4

HOLD

The Setup

Your friend waves you over.

She's sitting with someone who hurt you last week.

If you go, it feels like giving in.

If you stay, it feels cold.

So you hover.

The moment moves on.

Your chest stays tight.

THE NAME

HOLD means you choose.

Go sit with her.

Or don't.

But stop waiting for the moment

to decide for you.

Even a small decision

can loosen the knot.

THE SHADOW

Sometimes when you hold a lot,
it starts to stick.
You become the one who decides fast.
The one who doesn't go back.
People get used to it.
You do too.
Then one day you pause.
And instead of feeling open,
it feels like there's less space than before.

THE TRY

Next time, choose a little earlier.
Before the thoughts get loud.
Before the hallway fills up.
Pick a place and sit.
Then notice:
Did your body soften after choosing?
Or stay tight?
That noticing is part of HOLD.

Chapter 5

BLEND

The Setup

In one place you're quiet and careful.

In another you're loud and loose.

Two laughs.

Two ways of sitting.

Sometimes you wonder which one is real.

THE NAME

BLEND means you stop trying to pick one.

You take pieces from both

and let something new form.

Not half and half.

Something that travels with you.

A version of you

that isn't locked to one room.

THE SHADOW

Sometimes when you blend a lot,
you get very good at adjusting.
You can feel a room quickly.
You can shift without thinking.
That can feel smooth.
But sometimes later,
when no one is around,
you pause.
Like you're waiting to see
who you are without the room.

THE TRY

Notice one small difference
between the places you move through.
A joke you only tell in one.
A habit you hide in another.
Carry it across.
See what stays.
See what changes.
That's BLEND.

Chapter 6

BREAK

The Setup

Everyone says there's a table that matters.

You try to sit there.

You get ignored.

After a while, the thought shifts.

Not "they're unkind."

But "I don't belong."

The table starts to feel real.

Like something solid you failed.

THE NAME

BREAK means you look again.

Who decided the table mattered?

Who keeps the story going?

You see it's not a law.

It's something people repeat.

And stories can be stepped away from.

THE SHADOW

Sometimes when you break things open,
you start seeing the cracks everywhere.

Rules feel thinner.

Groups feel less fixed.

That can feel freeing.

But sometimes later,

when something real is offered,

you hesitate.

Not because it's fake.

Just because you're used to standing outside.

THE TRY

Pick one thing people treat as permanent.

A rule.

A ranking.

A quiet agreement.

Ask yourself:

Who made this true?

You don't have to say anything.

Just hold the question.

That's BREAK.

Chapter 7

DANCE

The Setup

You and someone keep looping.

Same fight.

Same words.

Same ending.

You both say sorry.

Nothing changes.

The pattern resets.

THE NAME

DANCE means you stop trying to win the loop.

You move differently instead.

A pause.

A softer reply.

A step sideways.

Not to fix everything.

Just to loosen the rhythm.

Sometimes movement

changes what words can't.

THE SHADOW

Sometimes when you dance a lot,
you get used to motion.
You learn how to shift before things lock.
How to keep everything moving.
That can feel alive.
But sometimes later,
when the moment slows,
stillness feels unfamiliar.
Like you've been moving so long
you forgot how to stay.

THE TRY

Next time the pattern starts,
pause once.
Just a little longer than usual.
Don't fix it.
Don't rush it.
Notice what appears
in the space you made.
That's DANCE.

Chapter 8

DISSOLVE

The Setup

People ask you what you are.

This or that.

Good at this or bad at that.

One thing or another.

You try answers.

They fit for a day.

Then they don't.

You start wondering if the problem is you.

THE NAME

DISSOLVE means you stop forcing an answer.

Not forever.

Just for now.

Maybe the question is too small.

Maybe you're still changing shape.

Leaving space

can sometimes help you breathe.

THE SHADOW

Sometimes when you dissolve a lot,
you get used to not answering.

You stay open.

You let things shift.

That can feel peaceful.

But then one day someone asks,

“What do you want?”

And you take longer than you thought you would.

Not wrong.

Just quieter inside than before.

THE TRY

Next time someone asks what you like,
try saying:

“I’m not sure yet.”

Just once.

Notice what that feels like
in your chest.

That’s DISSOLVE.

Chapter 9

PLAY

The Setup

Your thoughts get loud.

You'll mess up.

You'll fail.

Everyone will see.

The more you push them away,

the heavier they feel.

Everything tightens.

THE NAME

PLAY means you change the weight.

Not by winning the argument.

By tilting it.

You make the thought

slightly strange.

Slightly lighter.

Not to pretend.

Just to loosen the grip.

Sometimes a small shift in tone

changes everything.

THE SHADOW

Sometimes when you play a lot,
lightness becomes your first move.
You learn how to bend heavy moments.
How to keep things from landing too hard.
That can feel freeing.
But sometimes later,
when something quiet matters,
you notice the urge to float past it.
Like staying light
takes effort too.

THE TRY

Pick one loud thought.
Change one small thing about it.
The voice.
The shape.
The sound.
Don't erase it.
Just bend it slightly.
Then take the next step anyway.
That's PLAY.

Chapter 10

Closing

You won't use these in order.

You might use three in one day.

Or none for a while.

Some will feel natural.

Some will feel strange.

That's okay.

Every way of standing

changes what you can see.

Something opens.

Something closes.

Choosing one thing

always means

not choosing something else.

That isn't failure.

That's how movement works.

These attitudes aren't answers.

They're positions.

You try one.

You notice.

You move again.

A flexible mind

isn't something you find.

It's something you practice.

One small shift at a time.

Chapter 11

For the Parent Holding This Book

One night, one of my kids was sitting across from me at the table, not eating.

Nothing dramatic.

No tears. No story.

Just quiet.

I asked what was wrong.

They said, “I don’t know.”

And I believed it.

Not because there was nothing there.

Because there was too much there.

That moment stayed with me.

I’m an artist. I’ve spent a lot of my life around children — my own, and many others. And I keep noticing these moments that don’t look big from the outside, but are huge on the inside.

Moments where a child isn’t asking for answers.

They’re just trying to figure out where to stand.

Because childhood is full of that.

Two things feeling true at the same time.

Every choice costing something.

Feelings arriving before language does.

This book came from sitting inside those moments.

Not trying to fix them.

Just staying with them long enough to notice how children naturally move.

Sometimes they choose.

Sometimes they step back.

Sometimes they stay open.

Sometimes they make light of it.

Sometimes they move around something instead of through it.

Later I found psychology has words for a lot of this.

But I didn’t start there.

I started at the table.

In cars.

In quiet walks.

In long pauses.

Maybe I care because the child in me never really left. I still

remember what it feels like to hold something and not have a name for it yet.

So this book isn't written from above.

It's written from inside.

If you give it to your child, don't over-explain it.

Just let it be there.

Sometimes what helps isn't clarity.

It's the feeling that someone understands the space you're in.

That's all this is.

One human

trying to leave a little more room

for another.

Companion Document

A guide for educators, psychologists, and thoughtful adults

Chapter 1

What This Book Is

Attitudes is a small, moment-based book for children navigating inner tension.

It is not a curriculum.

It is not a therapy manual.

It is not a behavioral framework.

It is a tool for moments.

Specifically, the moments when a child feels pulled in two directions and doesn't yet have language for what they are experiencing.

Two friendships.

Two homes.

Two versions of themselves.

Moments where choosing feels like losing something.

This book offers positions — simple ways of standing inside those moments without rushing to resolve them.

Not an academic model.

A translation of complex thinking into something usable.

Chapter 2

Where This Work Comes From

This book did not begin as a research project.

It began as observation.

As a father of four, I kept noticing recurring moments in children's lives — moments of quiet paralysis, where something meaningful was happening internally but there were no words for it.

Instead of trying to fix those moments, I became interested in how children could learn to stand inside them differently.

Over time, I started experimenting with simple mental positions — small shifts in stance that children could try in real life.

Only later did I discover that many of these intuitive patterns echoed ideas in developmental psychology: cognitive flexibility, dialectical thinking, identity formation, and emotional regulation.

This work sits at the intersection of lived experience and ideas.

Chapter 3

The Core Idea

At the center of the book is a simple truth:
Every way of standing gives something.
Every way of standing takes something.
Every decision opens a door
and quietly closes another.
Children already feel this.
They just don't have language for it yet.
The book does not try to eliminate ambiguity.
It tries to make ambiguity livable.

Chapter 4

What the Book Offers

The book introduces six “attitudes” — temporary cognitive positions children can try when they feel stuck.
They are not identities.
They are not personality types.
They are not prescriptions.
They are movements.
Ways of shifting stance when something feels rigid.
The goal is not clarity.
The goal is mobility.
A child who can shift perspective is a child who can grow.

Chapter 5

The Six Attitudes

(Conceptual Overview)

HOLD

The ability to choose and stand somewhere, even when every option feels imperfect.

A movement toward agency.

BLEND

The ability to integrate multiple versions of self without collapsing into one.

A movement toward integration.

BREAK

The ability to step back and question the structure itself.

A movement toward perspective.

. . .

DANCE

The ability to move within patterns instead of trying to win them.

A movement toward relational flexibility.

DISSOLVE

The ability to stay open when identity is still forming.

A movement toward spaciousness.

PLAY

The ability to loosen intensity through lightness and reframing.

A movement toward psychological flexibility.

- emotional ambiguity

Chapter 6

Intended Use

This book works best as a situational companion.

It is not meant to be assigned cover-to-cover.

It is meant to be encountered.

Children often:

- open it randomly
- land on something familiar
- read briefly
- stop

This is correct usage.

The book is designed for:

- quiet moments
- post-conflict reflection
- identity tension

Chapter 7

What This Book Is Not

To preserve clarity, it helps to name what this book is not.

It is not:

- a diagnostic tool
- a therapy replacement
- a behavioral intervention model
- a moral framework

It does not aim to resolve inner conflict.

It aims to make space for it.

Chapter 8

Research Resonance

Cognitive Flexibility

Research in executive function shows that middle childhood is a key period for developing the ability to shift mental frameworks rather than becoming stuck in rigid interpretations.

The book provides simple external scaffolds for that flexibility.

SELF-DISTANCING

Studies in emotion regulation suggest that adopting different mental vantage points can reduce overwhelm and increase insight.

Each attitude functions as a structured perspective shift.

DIALECTICAL THINKING

Work in dialectical psychology highlights the importance of

holding opposing ideas without collapsing into rigid either/or thinking.

Several attitudes model this capacity in accessible ways.

IDENTITY DEVELOPMENT

Developmental research shows that periods of non-definition and exploration are natural and often healthy parts of identity formation.

The book normalizes openness without pathologizing uncertainty.

EMOTIONAL REGULATION

Modern emotion research emphasizes reframing, perspective shifting, and cognitive flexibility over suppression.

Each attitude can be understood as a different regulatory posture.

Chapter 9 *For Educators and Psychologists*

This book is best understood as a bridge.

A bridge between:

- lived experience and theory
- emotional reality and language
- complexity and usability

It is not a clinical framework translated downward.

It is an experiential tool that happens to resonate with psychological research.

For professionals, it may be helpful to think of the book as:

A piece of field design —

an attempt to make flexible thinking portable for children.

It is presence.

Chapter 10

How Adults Can Use It

The most effective way to introduce the book is lightly.

Offer, don't assign.

Instead of instruction, try invitation:

- “You might find something in here.”
- “You don't have to read all of it.”
- “See if anything feels familiar.”

Avoid interpretation before reading.

Let the child discover themselves inside it.

Afterward, simple questions are enough:

- “Did anything feel familiar?”
- “Did anything shift?”
- “Would you try a different one next time?”

The adult's role is not analysis.

Chapter 11

A Note on Tone

Children are highly sensitive to emotional authenticity.

This book intentionally avoids:

- moral instruction
- diagnostic language
- therapeutic tone

It aims for something quieter:

recognition without pressure.

The hope is that children feel understood, not guided.

Chapter 12

The Spirit of the Work

This project comes from a simple curiosity:

What if children didn't have to rush toward certainty?

What if they were given permission to explore inner complexity without immediately resolving it?

And what if they had language for the in-between?

Not answers.

Positions.

Not certainty.

Mobility.

If even one page gives a child a little more room to breathe,
a little more permission to shift,
that is enough.

Chapter 13

Closing

This book does not aim to finish anything.

It aims to keep something alive:

the ability to move.

Because a flexible mind is not something we achieve once.

It is something we practice.

Again and again.

In small moments.

In quiet ways.